ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Snakes and Ladders: How Misvot Bring Us Close

Derech Hashem, Maamar HaIkarim

Sefer: Maamar HaIkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar HaIkarim, essay 3: the Torah and the misvot, the purpose of life (paragraph 2 to the end of the essay) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 2 June 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: the purpose of creation

On Monday the first paragraph of the third essay set out the purpose of creation. God, the ultimate good, wants to give the ultimate goodness, which is found only in Him. Since He cannot create another ultimate good, He allows people to cleave to Him. And because He wants us to be the owners of that goodness, He places us in a world of good and bad, where by choosing good we attach ourselves to Him. Humanity is the focus of the universe.

The Rabbi added a point he had not made last time about nisayon coming from nes, a banner. In the Amidah we say "raise a banner to gather our exiles". The word nes means to raise. A miracle is called a nes because it raises God's name.

Holiness is closeness

God created in the world an existence of good and bad, of kedushah and tumah. The Rabbi asked the group not to translate these simply as "holiness" and "impurity", as if they were something mystical. The Ramhal defines them plainly: kedushah is closeness to God, and tumah is distance from Him. Kedushah is the light of God's presence resting on a person; tumah is distance and concealment. God created spiritual means through which light or darkness can come down.

What are those means? The misvot and the averot. God set aside actions that draw down holiness and told us to do many of them, and actions that draw down impurity and told us to refrain from them. And again, the result is not a prize but a consequence. "A person who does exercise will lose weight. It's not a reward that they lose weight. It's a consequence."

Snakes and ladders

A participant offered an analogy that delighted the Rabbi: the game of snakes and ladders. You want to reach the top and cleave to God. You have been given the rules: the ladders are the misvot that take you up, and the snakes are the sins and temptations that bring you down. "It's a beautiful analogy! I'll use that in future shiurim."

The one difference, he added, is that life is not a game of chance. "It's not luck of the dice." How you move is your choice. Will you jump over the snake or slide down it? And the size of the snake, the seriousness of the sin, decides how far you fall.

A participant asked whether we are living in a world of tumah, more hidden than ever; others pointed to the return of the State of Israel and of the Kotel. The Rabbi acknowledged that we no longer have prophets and that God's word is not as clear as it once was. But he questioned the claim that ours is the worst generation. Look how much Torah there is today and how many yeshivot. "We have many miracles happening today and we are living a blessed life." Another participant noted that temptations are now broadcast worldwide, and the Rabbi allowed that this may be so.

Walking with keri

He then shared a thought from his Shabbat sermon on Parashat Behukkotai. The word keri appears seven times in the curses there and nowhere else in the Torah: "if you walk with Me with keri". Some translate it as hostility or rebelliousness. The Rambam connects it to mikreh, chance. The root of all the curses is seeing life as random, with no hashgahah.

God's response is measure for measure. If you want to walk with Me as if everything is an accident, "fine, I'll leave you to that. I'll leave you to nature." And for a small nation surrounded by enemies, nature and statistics mean defeat. This, the Rabbi said, is what concealment is. It is why putting oneself under charms and luck is so costly: "you're walking with Him with keri", and God leaves you to it.

The more misvot a person does, the more he cleaves to God and enjoys His goodness; the more he sins, the further away he is. The worst outcome is not suffering but being pushed away entirely, ceasing to exist, "not allowed into the stadium". In between are countless levels of closeness and distance, which are the levels of the World to Come.

We affect the whole world, and teshuvah

The Ramhal adds that our choices do not work in a vacuum. Each person can also help rectify or damage the world around him, and the more people work to rectify it, the closer it comes to its tikkun. The good a person does for the world counts to his merit, and the damage he causes adds to his distance. Our main focus should always be ourselves, but we are part of a larger system.

How does this work? Through the parallel between the spiritual and physical worlds taught in the previous essay. For everything else, influence flows from above to below: a lion's nature to maul begins above and comes down, and the animal has no choice. Human beings are the one creature that works from below to above. Our actions stir the forces above us, which then send the effect back down, creating "a virtuous cycle" (or a vicious one). This is the idea that one misvah brings another. A misvah arouses the power of holiness; a sin strengthens concealment, which makes it harder to arouse ourselves next time.

A participant asked how teshuvah fits into this system. The Rabbi explained that there are two kinds. One simply wipes the sins out, together with their knock-on effects. The other actually transforms them, presumably turning their effect into something good.

There would be no class on Shavuot or the following Thursday; the next class would be on 13 June.

Summary

- Kedushah means closeness to God, and tumah means distance and concealment; misvot and averot are the means to each.
- Life is like snakes and ladders, except that nothing depends on the dice; every move is our choice.
- Walking with keri, seeing life as chance, is the root of the curses: God leaves us to nature.
- Our actions stir the spiritual world and come back down, creating virtuous or vicious cycles for us and for the world.
- Teshuvah can either erase sins or transform them.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/pgG9lYIZIu4 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com